EXPERIMENT 2

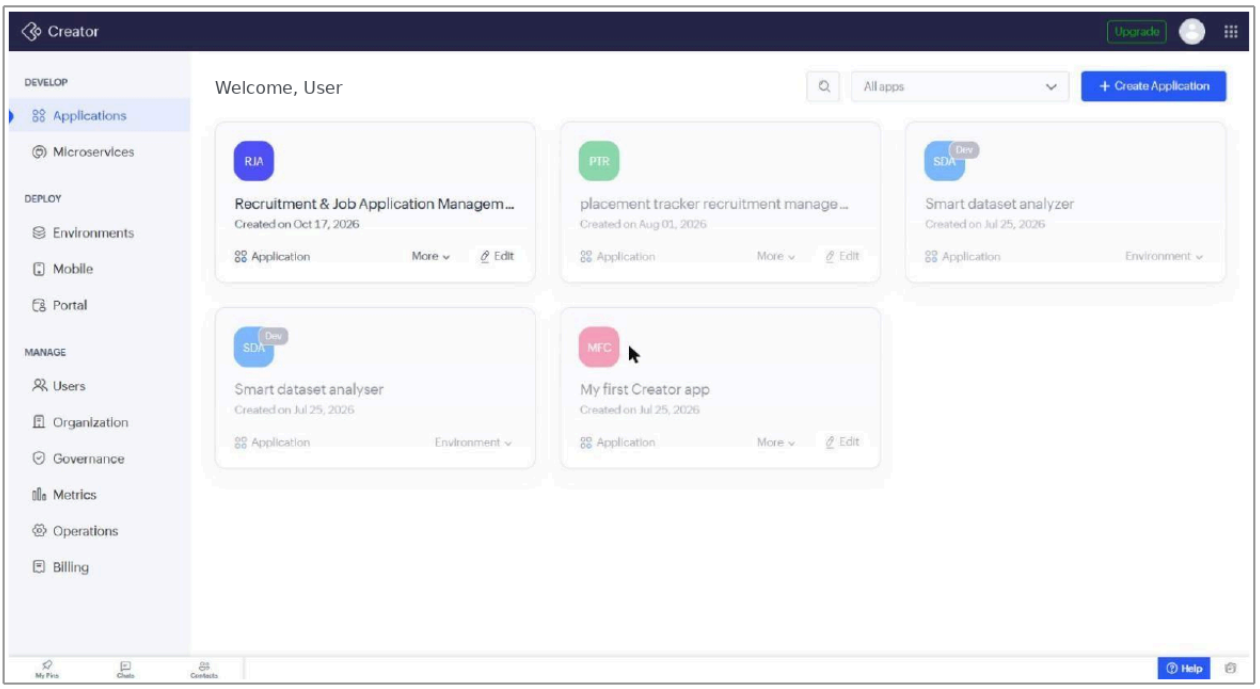
Setting up a Zoho Creator account and exploring the platform architecture and interface

Aim

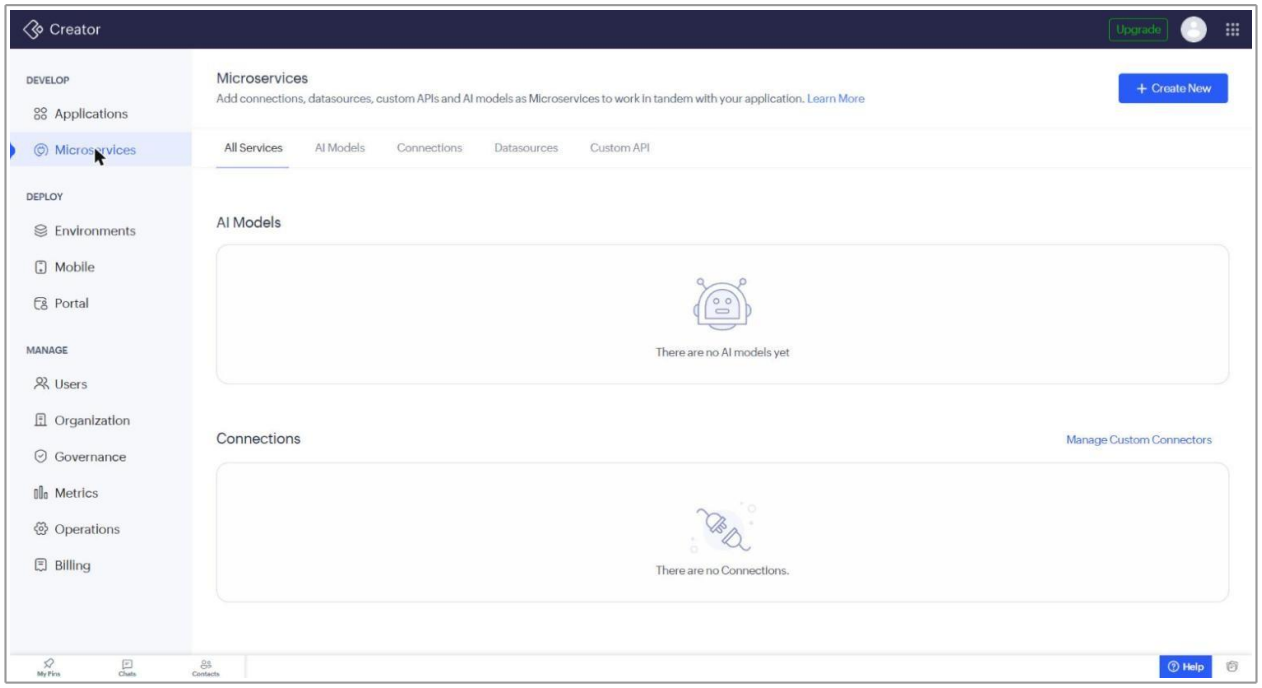
To get access to a Zoho Creator account, to explore the platform's main sections, menus and application-building tools that are available in that account, and to create the application "Recruitment & Job Application Management" that will be used in the later experiments.

Procedure

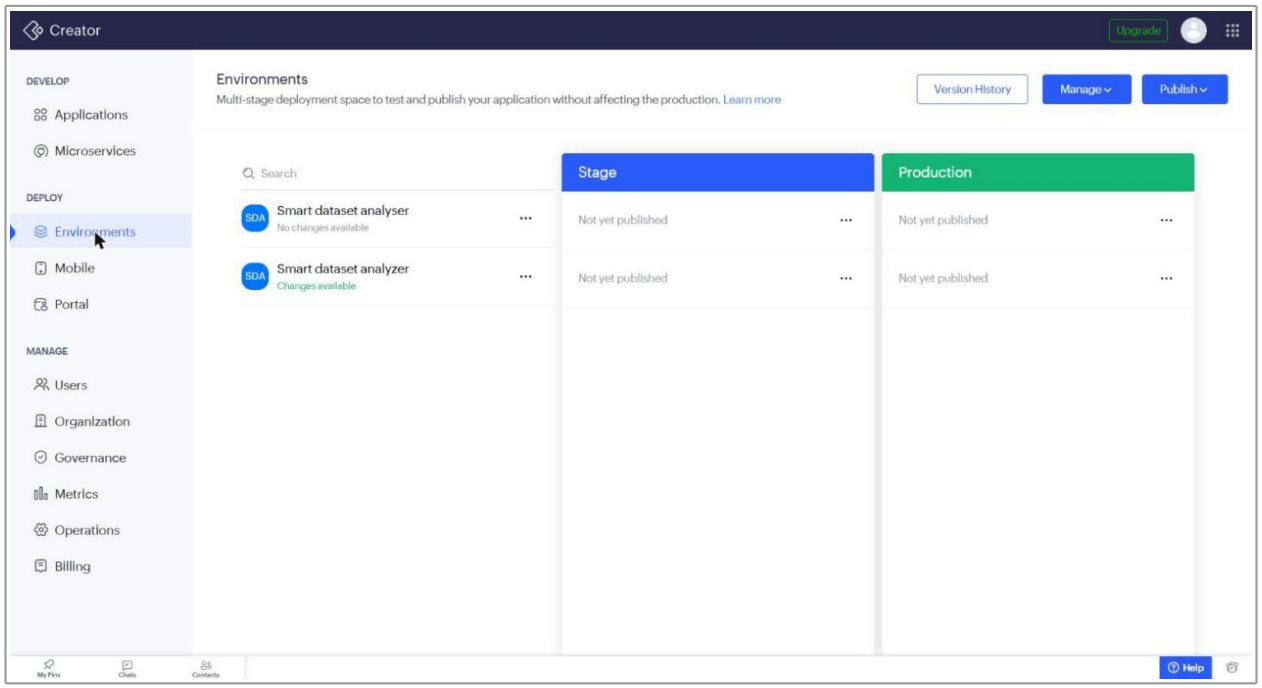
1. **Open Zoho Creator.** In Chrome, open creator.zoho.com. It redirects to the Zoho Creator product page. Click the red **Access Zoho Creator** button. Because the student was already signed in, Zoho opened the Creator home page (address creator.zoho.in/userhome/.../admindashboard).
2. **Study the home page (dashboard).** The **Applications** page lists all applications as cards. The left sidebar groups the platform into **Develop** (Applications, Microservices), **Deploy** (Environments, Mobile, Portal) and **Manage** (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing). The blue **Create Application** button is at the top right.



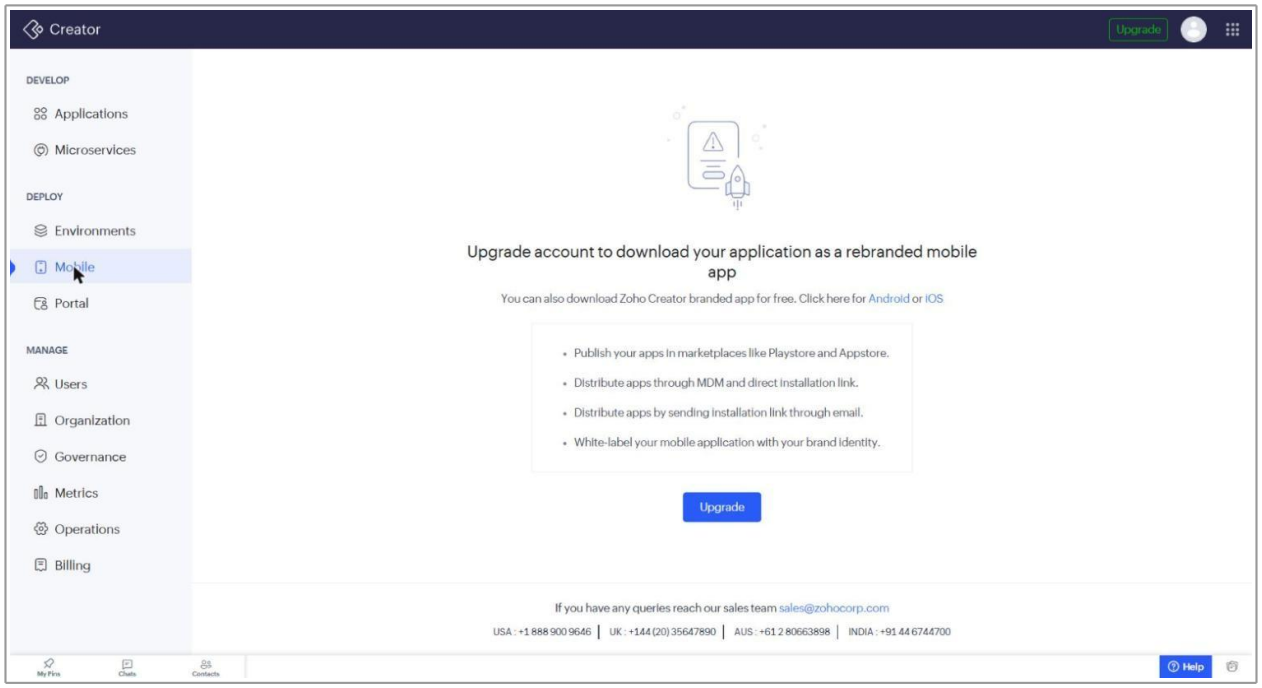
3. **Open Microservices** in the sidebar. This page is used to add connections, data sources, custom APIs and AI models that work with an application. Its tabs are All Services, AI Models, Connections, Datasources and Custom API.



4. **Open Environments.** This is the multi-stage deployment space. Each application can move through **Stage** and **Production**, and the page has Version History, Manage and Publish buttons.



5. **Open Mobile.** The page offers to download an application as a rebranded mobile app, which needs a plan upgrade.



6. **Open Portal.** Portals give external users their own sign-in experience. The page asks for an upgrade to enable it.

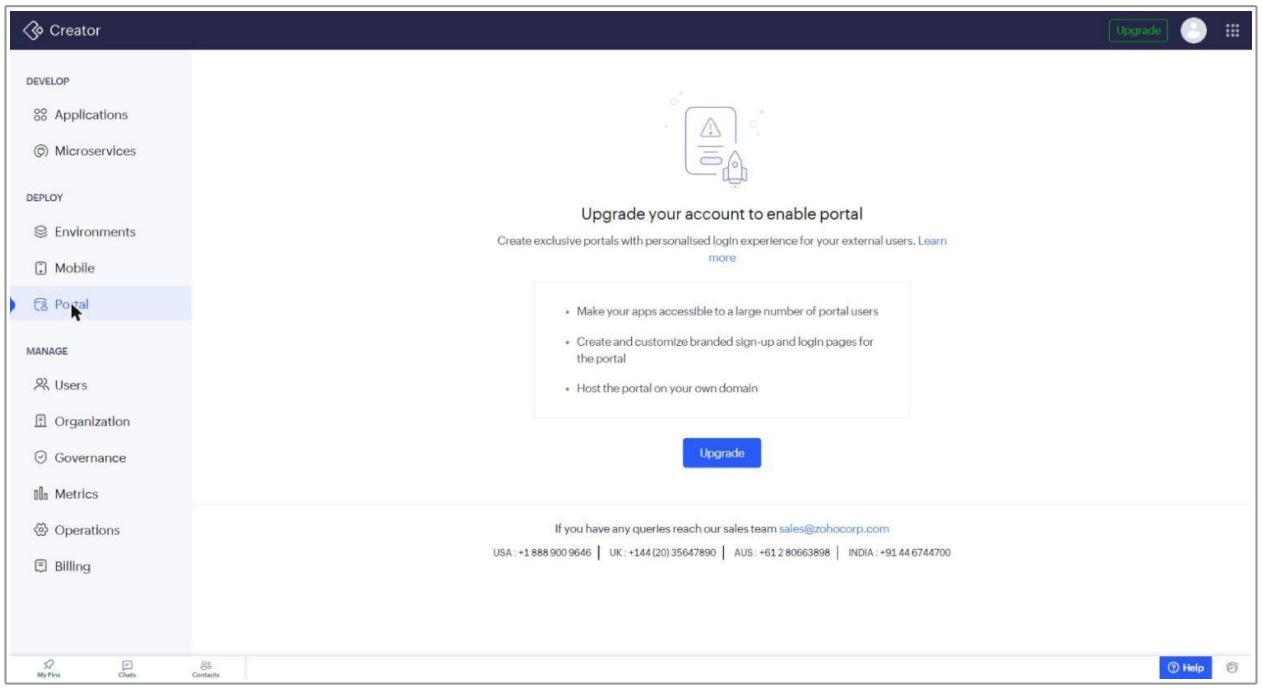
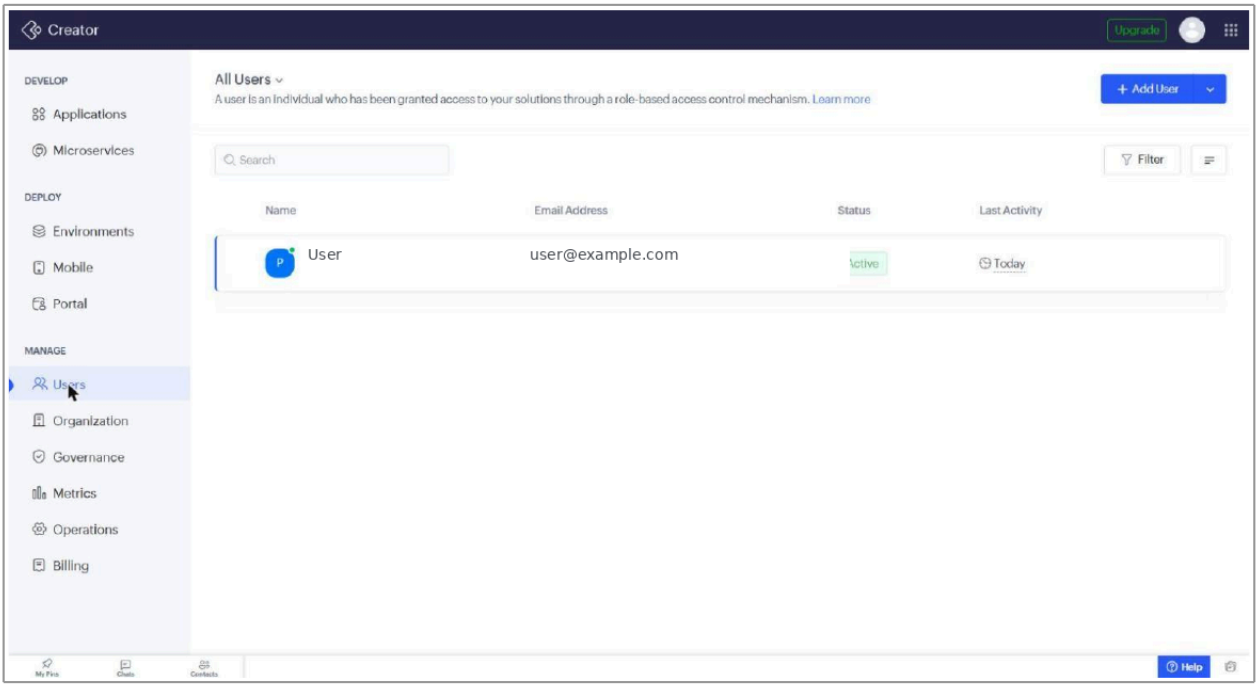
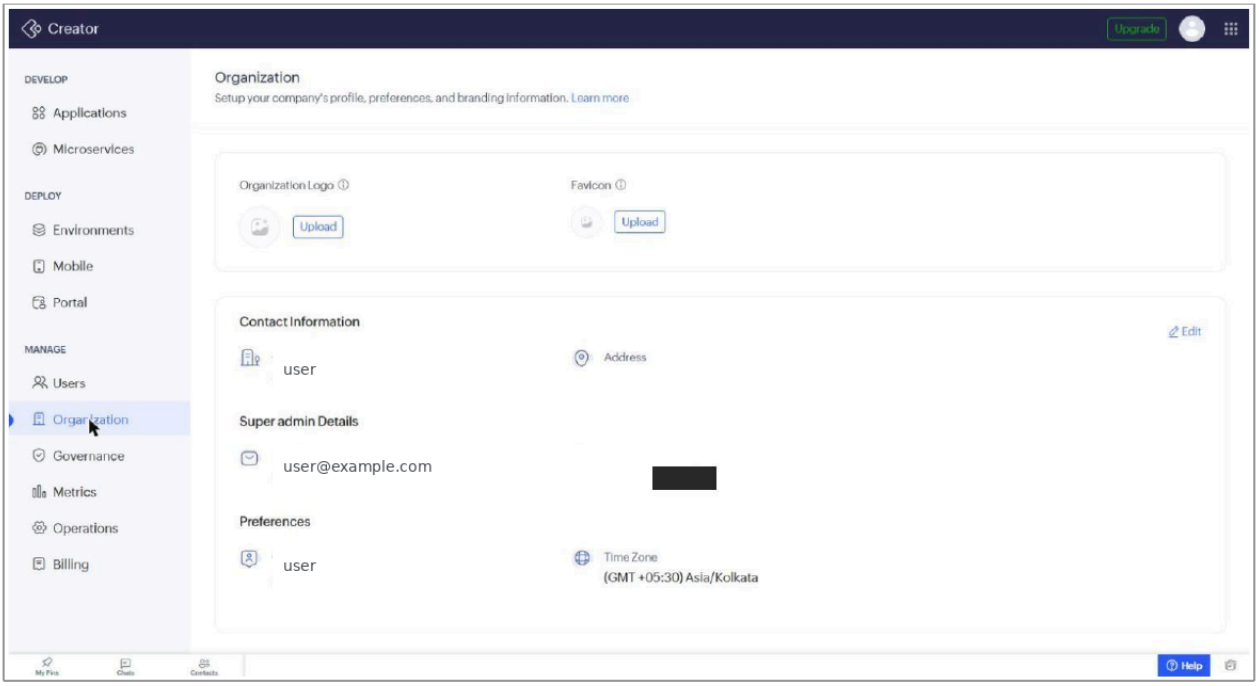


Figure 5: Portal page. Portals are not enabled on this account without an upgrade.

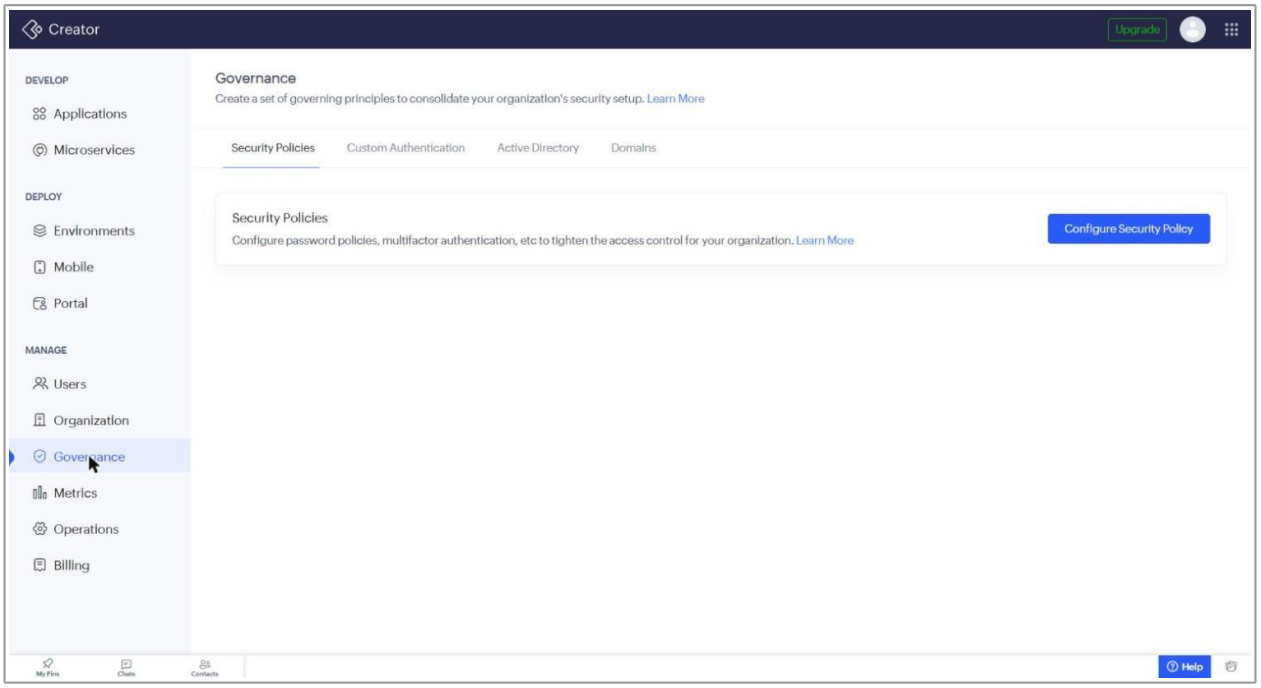
7. **Open Users.** This page lists the people who have access through role-based access control. It has Add User, Search and Filter. The account has one user, marked **SUPER ADMIN** with status Active.



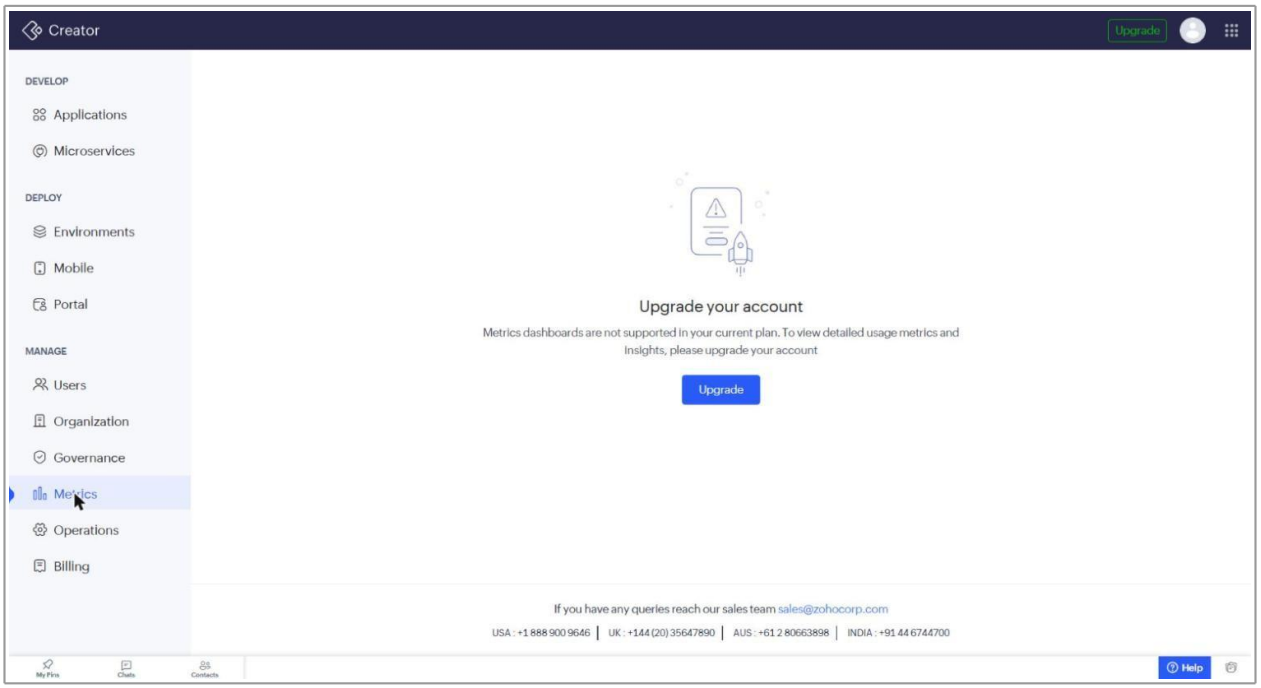
8. **Open Organization.** Here the organisation logo, favicon, contact information, super admin details, organisation namespace and time zone (GMT +05:30, Asia/Kolkata) are shown. (The phone number has been hidden in this record.)



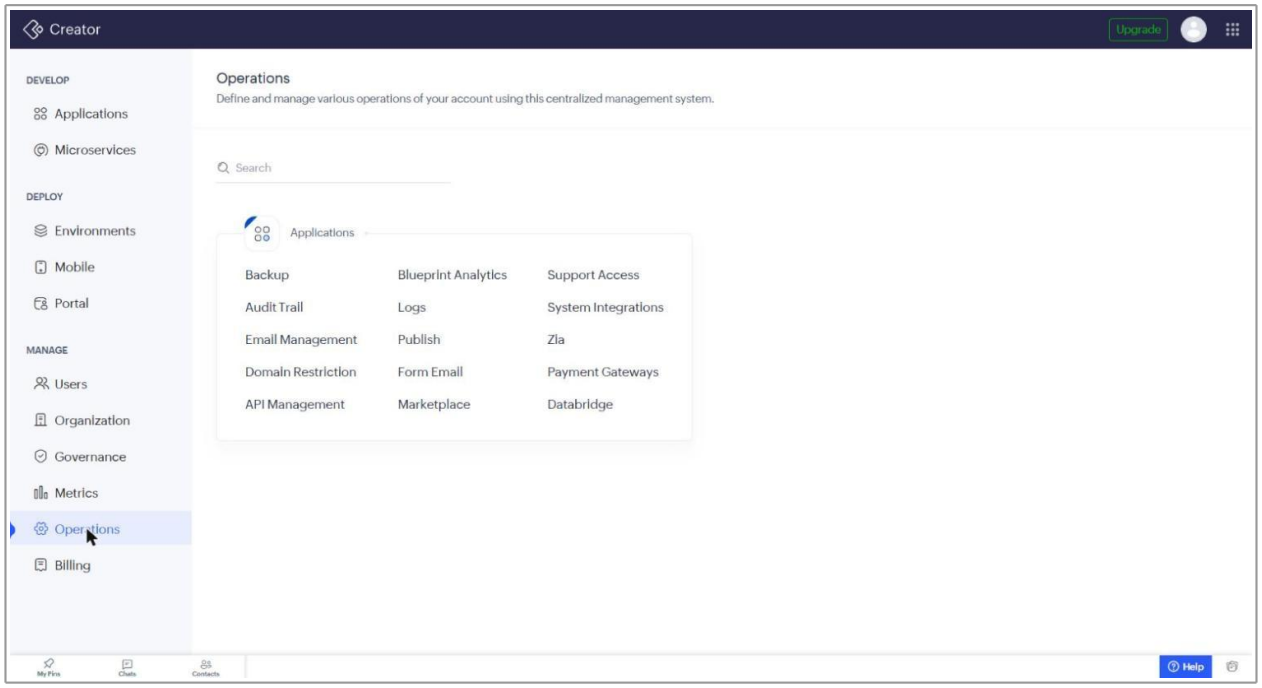
9. **Open Governance.** It has four tabs: Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory and Domains. The Security Policies tab offers a **Configure Security Policy** button. Nothing was changed on this page.



10. **Open Metrics.** The page reports that metrics dashboards are not supported in the current plan.

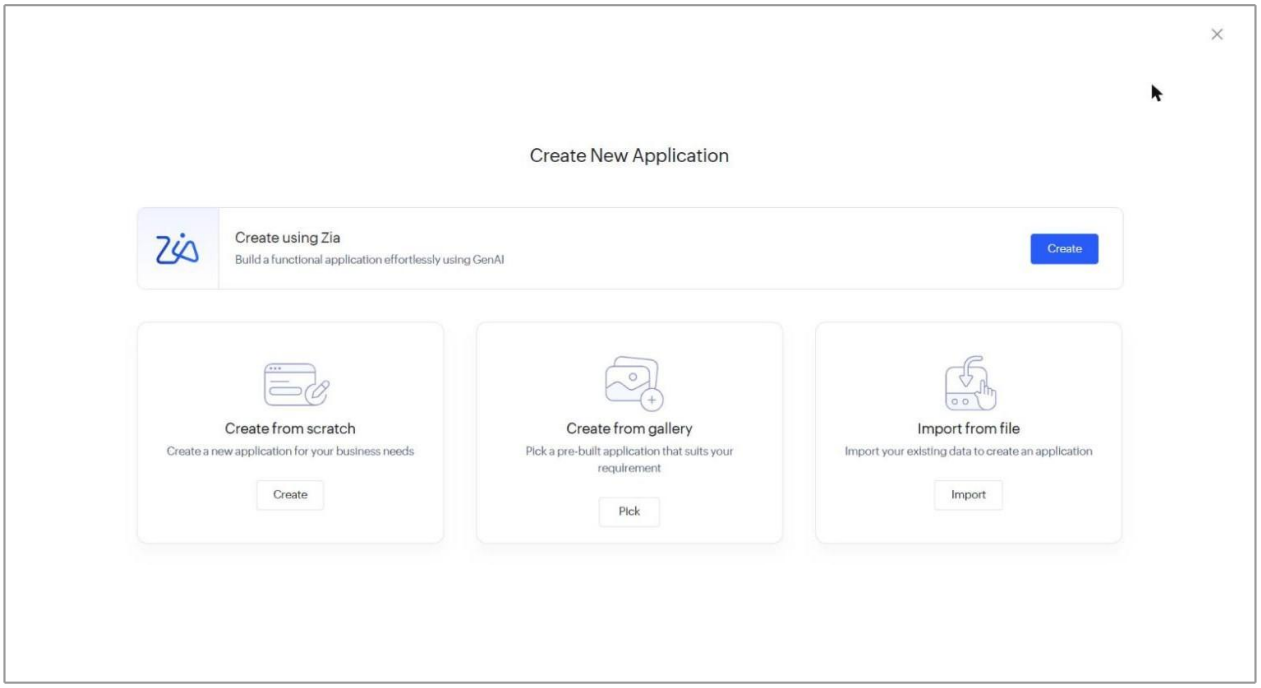


11. **Open Operations.** This central management page lists 15 operations under Applications: Backup, Audit Trail, Email Management, Domain Restriction, API Management, Blueprint Analytics, Logs, Publish, Form Email, Marketplace, Support Access, System Integrations, Zia, Payment Gateways and Databridge. None of them was opened or changed.

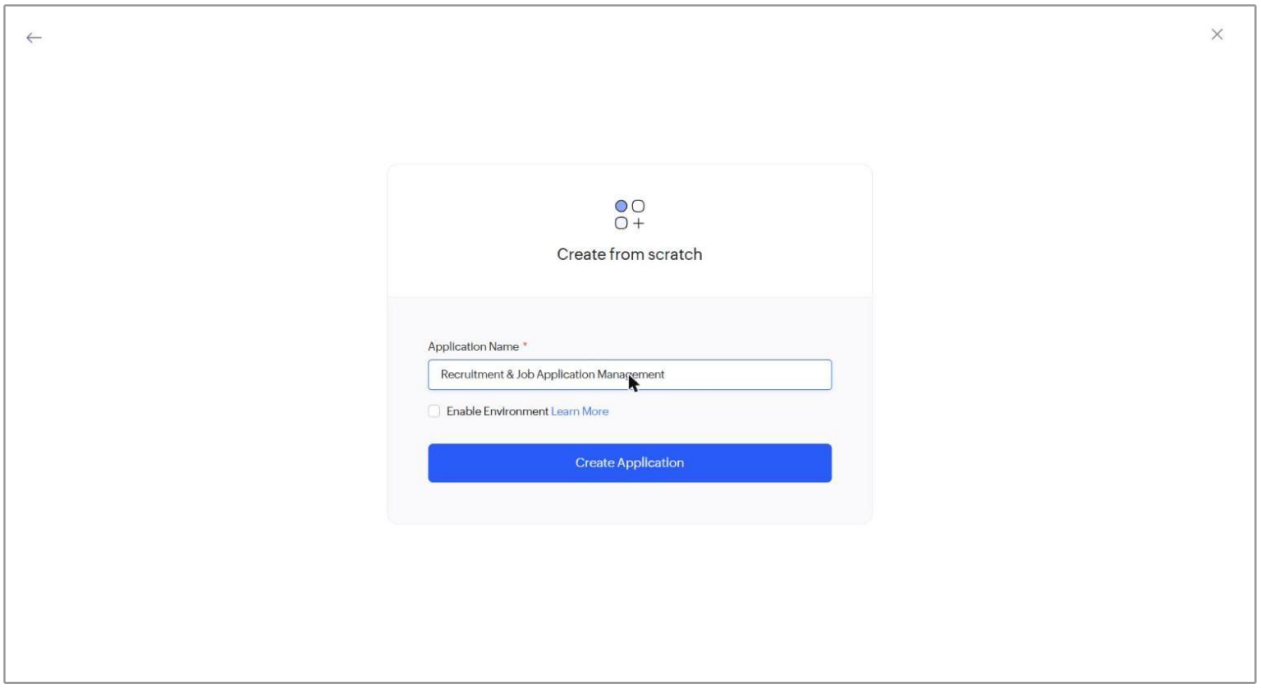


12. **Billing** appears at the bottom of the sidebar. It was **not opened** in this experiment, so nothing is recorded about it.

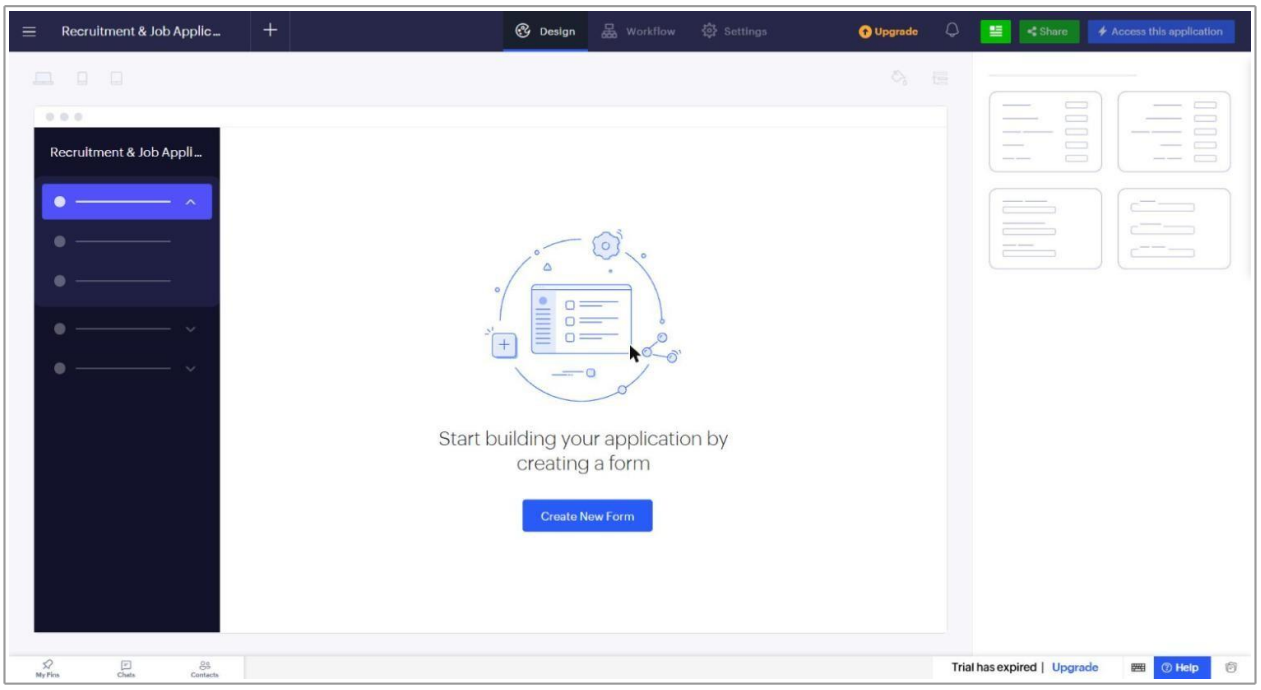
13. **Start creating the application.** Go back to **Applications** and click **Create Application**. The Create New Application screen offers four ways: **Create using Zia** (generative AI), **Create from scratch**, **Create from gallery** and **Import from file**. Choose **Create from scratch**.



14. **Name the application.** Type **Recruitment & Job Application Management** in the Application Name box, leave *Enable Environment* unchecked and click **Create Application**.

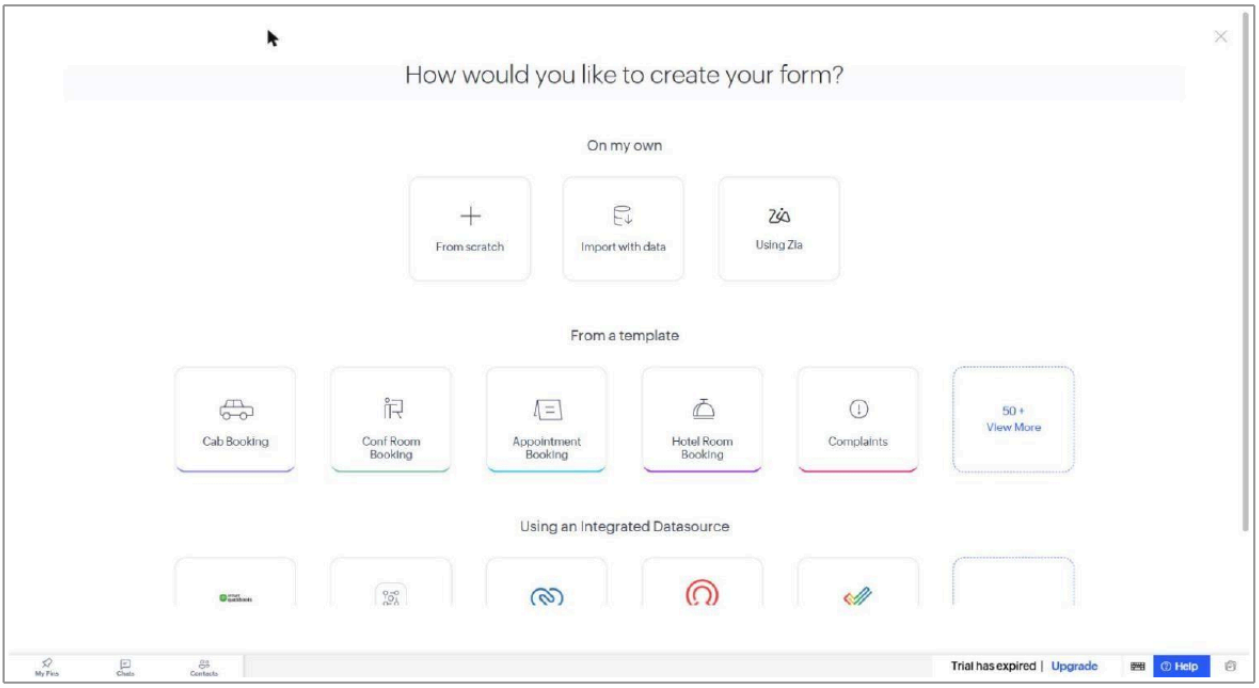


15. **Open the new application.** After creation, Zoho opens the application builder (address ending /recruitment-job-application-management/edit). The top bar has the menu button, the application name, a **+** button, the tabs **Design**, **Workflow** and **Settings**, plus **Share** and **Access this application**. The canvas says "Start building your application by creating a form". The bottom bar shows "Trial has expired | Upgrade".

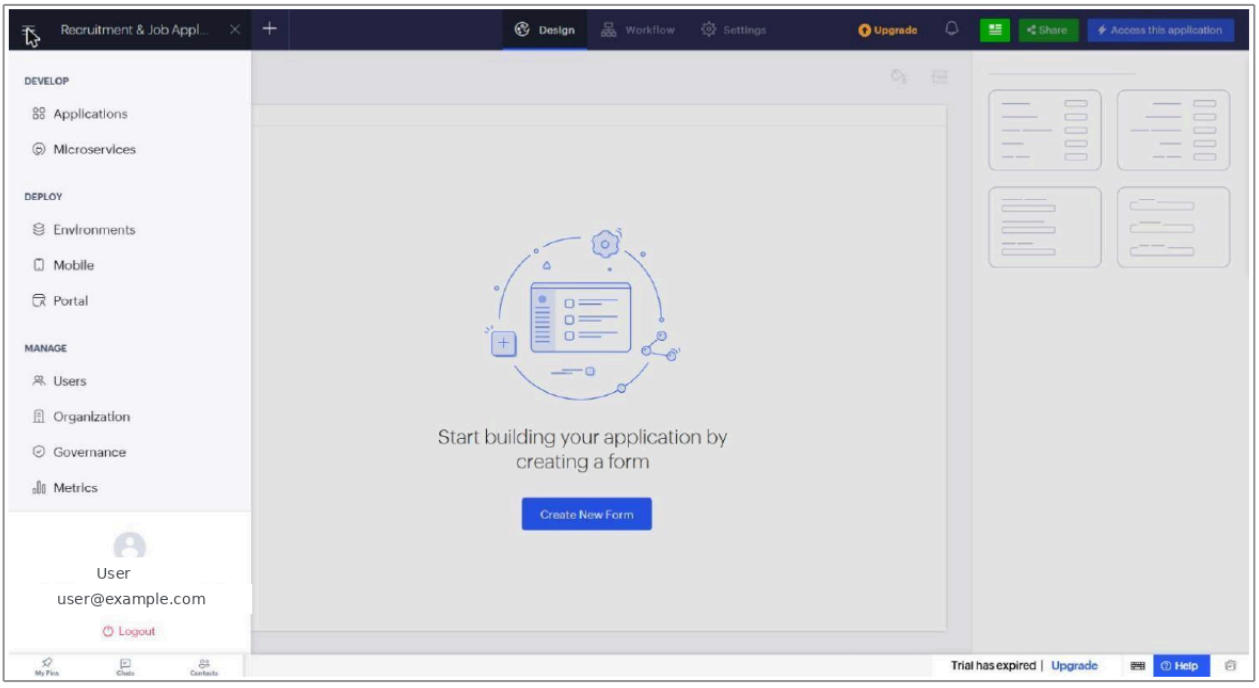


16. **Try the Workflow and Settings tabs.** Both tabs look greyed out and did not open when clicked. The application has no form yet; the exact reason was not investigated further.

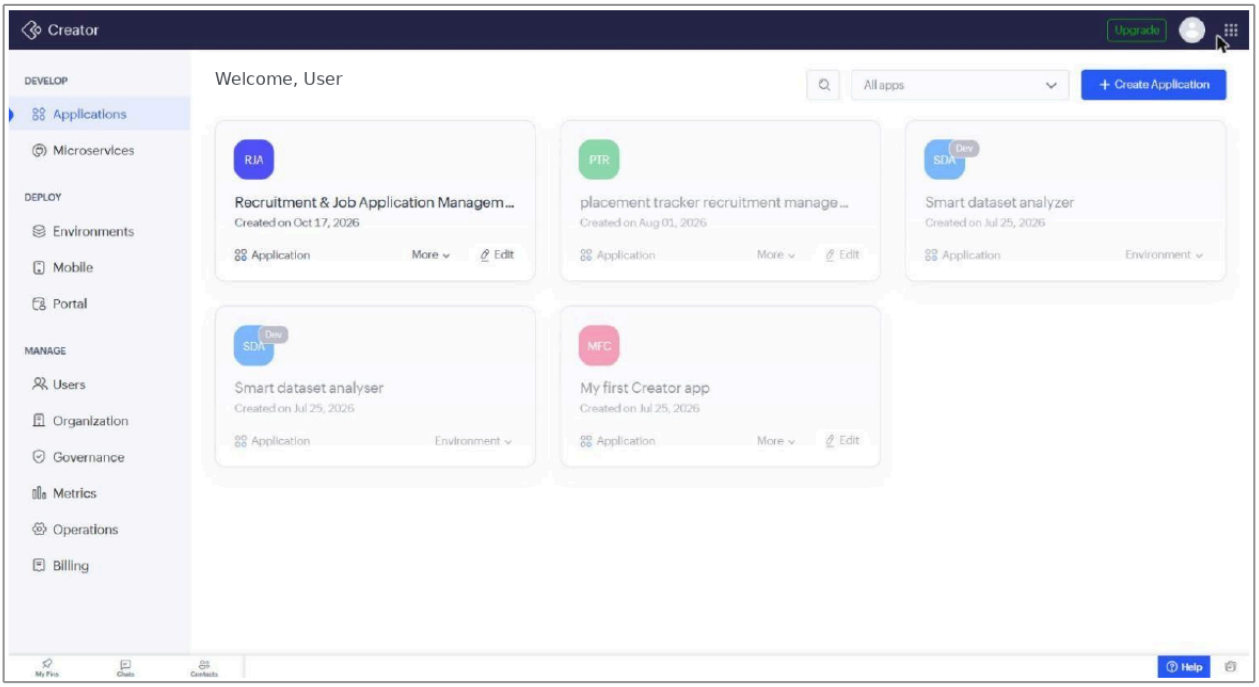
17. **Look at the + (add) menu.** Clicking **+** opens "How would you like to create your form?" with **From scratch**, **Import with data**, **Using Zia**, a list of templates (for example Cab Booking, Appointment Booking, Complaints; "50+ View More") and integrated data sources. The dialog was closed without creating a form, because building forms belongs to a later experiment.



18. **Open the builder menu.** The button at the top left opens the same Develop, Deploy and Manage sections, the user profile and Logout.



19. **Verify the result.** Return to **Applications**. The new card **Recruitment & Job Application Management** is listed first with "Created on Oct 17, 2026", and there is only one application with that name.



Output

Platform architecture as seen in the account (Concept + Observed)

Zoho Creator is a cloud (browser-based) platform. Applications are assembled from building blocks and are managed from an administration area. The table maps the blocks to what was actually seen in this account.

Layer	Component	Role	Seen in this account
Build	Application builder (Design, Workflow, Settings tabs)	Where one application is designed and configured.	Yes, Figures 13 and 14 (empty application)
Data	Forms	Define fields and store each submission as a record.	Only the form-creation options; no form built yet
Presentation	Reports and Pages	Show the stored records and custom screens.	Not explored in this experiment
Logic	Workflows and Deluge scripting	Automate actions such as sending an email on submission.	Workflow tab visible but not opened
Connect	Microservices (AI models, connections, data sources, custom APIs)	Link the application to other services.	Yes, Figure 2 (all empty)
Deploy	Environments, Mobile, Portal	Stage and production release; mobile and portal access.	Yes, Figures 3 to 5 (Mobile and Portal need an upgrade)
Manage	Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing	Account-level people, security, monitoring and tools.	Yes, Figures 6 to 10 (Metrics needs an upgrade; Billing not opened)

Summary of sections explored

Section	Result	Figure
Applications (home)	Available. Lists applications; Create Application works.	1, 16
Microservices	Available. No AI models or connections configured.	2
Environments	Available. Stage and Production view.	3
Mobile	Upgrade prompt shown.	4
Portal	Upgrade prompt shown.	5
Users	Available. One Super Admin user.	6
Organization	Available. Profile and preferences visible.	7
Governance	Available. Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory, Domains tabs.	8
Metrics	Not supported in the current plan.	9
Operations	Available. 15 management tools listed.	10
Billing	Not opened.	-
Application builder	Opened for the new application; Workflow and Settings tabs did not open.	13, 14, 15

Application created

Item	Status
Application name	Recruitment & Job Application Management (created from scratch)
Created on	Oct 17, 2026 (as shown by Zoho Creator on the application card, Figure 16)
Contents	Empty. No form, report, page or workflow has been built.

Result

The Zoho Creator account was accessed (already signed in by the student), and the main platform sections, the account-level menus and the application builder were explored and documented with real screenshots. The application **Recruitment & Job Application Management** was created from scratch and verified on the Applications list. Some areas were limited or unavailable on this account (Mobile, Portal and Metrics need an upgrade; Billing was not opened; the builder's Workflow and Settings tabs did not open on the empty application). Building forms and later features is left for the next experiments.